



STORM CLOUDS hang over the Caltech-managed Jet Propulsion Laboratory in La Cañada Flintridge.

Iran fires on ships as strait is shut again

Standoff over Hormuz resumes one day after opening, with call for U.S. to end blockade.

By SAM METZ AND SAMY MAGDY

CAIRO — Iran reversed its decision to reopen the Strait of Hormuz and fired on a tanker attempting to pass on Saturday. It also warned that it would continue to block transit through the strait as long as the U.S. blockade of Iranian ports remained in effect.

Confusion over the critical choke point threatened to deepen the energy crisis roiling the global economy and push the two countries toward renewed conflict, even as mediators expressed confidence that a new deal was within reach.

Iran's joint military command said "control of the Strait of Hormuz has returned to its previous state ... under strict management and control of the armed forces."

Two Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps gunboats opened fire on a tanker, and an unknown projectile hit a container vessel, damaging some containers, the British military's United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations center said. It reported the tanker and crew as safe, without identifying the vessel or its destination.

TankerTrackers.com reported vessels were forced to turn around in the strait after they were fired upon by Iran, including two Indian-flagged ships. India's foreign ministry said it summoned Iran's ambassador over the "serious incident."

Saturday's developments came after President Trump said the blockade "will remain in full force" until Tehran reaches a deal with the U.S. that includes its nuclear program. Tehran had reopened the strait to commercial vessels on Friday.

Roughly one-fifth of the world's oil passes through the strait, and further limits would squeeze already constrained supply, driving prices higher once again. Iran's Friday announcement about the reopening came as a 10-day truce between Israel and the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon appeared to hold.

For Iran, the strait's closure — imposed after the U.S. and Israel launched the war on Feb. 28 during talks over Tehran's nuclear pro-

[See Strait, A5]

A NEW BUDGET THREAT TO JPL

Among the NASA endeavors that could be slashed is further exploration of Mars

By Justine McDaniel

WASHINGTON — NASA recaptured the world's attention with Artemis II, which took astronauts to the moon and back for the first time in half a century. But the agency's scientific projects could again be under threat as the Trump administration makes a renewed push to drastically cut their funding — including at the Jet Propulsion Laboratory.

The cuts, proposed in the Trump administration's 2027 budget request to Congress, would pose further challenges to the already weakened Caltech-managed lab and could be broadly damaging to American efforts to bring back new discoveries from space. They echo last year's attempt by the administration to slash NASA funding, which Congress rejected.

Though the Artemis project is billed as laying a foundation for a crewed NASA mission to Mars, exploration of the Red Planet is among the endeavors that could be slashed. The rover currently exploring Mars' ancient river delta and a mission to orbit Venus are among projects with JPL involvement targeted for spending cuts, according to an analysis of the NASA

budget proposal by the nonprofit Planetary Society.

"This isn't [because] they're not producing good science anymore. There's no rhyme or reason to it," said Casey Dreier, chief of space policy at the Planetary Society, which led opposition to the administration's similar effort to cut NASA funding last year.

This time, the administration is asking Congress to cut NASA funding by 23% — including a 46% cut to its science programs, which are responsible for developing spacecraft, sending them into outer space to observe and analyzing the data they send back.

The proposal would cancel 53 science missions and reduce funding for others, according to the Planetary Society analysis. The effort to pare down NASA Science comes amid the Trump administration's broader effort to cut scientific research across federal agencies.

The plan swiftly drew bipartisan criticism from members of Congress, who rejected the administration's similar 2026

[See JPL, A7]

After fires, many are building all-electric

Costs and climate change have homeowners reconsidering gas

By BLANCA BEGERT



LEO CHENG stands on the site where he and his wife lived in Altadena. He is planning a passive home.

No one is forcing fire survivors in Altadena and Pacific Palisades to rebuild their new homes all-electric. But many of them want to, for health reasons, cost savings, or because they're worried about climate change.

Burning gas and propane for cooking, water heating and space heating in California homes and businesses creates 10% of the state's greenhouse gas emissions. It also releases pollutants indoors.

That's why, in recent years, state policy has pushed toward electrification, and about 39% of new homes in California in 2024 went in without gas lines. Only 8% of all homes were all-electric in 2020.

Yet after last year's fires, Gov. Gavin Newsom waived a 2025 building code that strongly encouraged electric heat pumps in new construction, allowing residents in the burn zones to build back to older, less efficient standards.

The city of L.A. also waived a requirement that new homes be all-electric.

Climate experts called these rollbacks a missed

[See All-electric, A11]

Meet Mexico's new top diplomat

Roberto Velasco Álvarez, 38, is the youngest person to hold the post but brings to it a deep knowledge of the U.S. **WORLD, A3**

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Interim shelters are falling short

Many in L.A. County's short-term housing go back to the streets, or unknown destinations. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 78/55. **B8**

A plan to raise reservoir's level

But actions to forestall Lake Powell crisis will also have consequences. **CALIFORNIA, B1**



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Hospice fraud persists in state despite alarms

California authorities had pledged to crack down after a Times investigation in 2020.

By HANNAH FRY AND RICHARD WINTON

Officials have failed to halt pervasive fraud in the hospice industry despite promises of reforms five years ago after learning of widespread corruption that targeted vulnerable patients.

California authorities promised to crack down after a Times investigation in late 2020 revealed that a cohort of mostly older Americans was being targeted by unscrupulous providers who would bill Medicare for hospice services and equipment for patients who they said were terminally ill, but who were in fact not dying.

The hospice industry,

particularly in Los Angeles County, had exploded in size, outpacing public need.

One of California's first moves was to put a moratorium on issuing new hospice licenses to give officials time to strengthen oversight. State officials and industry representatives crafted emergency regulations that they said would address gaps in hospice licensing requirements to weed out bad actors.

But years later, those regulations have still not been enacted. And problems that have plagued the industry persist despite highly publicized enforcement efforts by the state and federal government, experts say.

The Trump administration has seized on California hospice fraud in recent months with a series of new arrests while blaming state officials for dropping the ball. California rejects the criticism but last week an-

[See Hospice, A8]

Judges fume as ICE detentions drag on

California's federal courts inundated with thousands of legal pleas from detainees.

By SONJA SHARP

Judge Troy Nunley was fed up.

Federal immigration officials had once again flouted his authority by keeping a man locked up in a California City detention center after Nunley ordered him released. When he was finally set free, the man was booted onto the street with no passport, driver's license or other personal effects. The judge's demand that the items be returned were met with silence.

And so on Tuesday, Nunley, the chief judge of the Eastern District of California, slapped Department of

Justice attorney Jonathan Yu with an official sanction and a \$250 fine.

In a scathing order, Nunley laid out why he was compelled to take such a rare step. The fine may have been less than some traffic tickets, but it's nearly unheard of for a judge to formally admonish a government lawyer.

By Yu's own admission, he was drowning in work. In his order, Nunley recounted the attorney's claim he'd been assigned more than 300 nearly identical cases in the last three months, all of immigrants in detention who argued they were being held without cause.

Court filings show many California cases involve longtime U.S. residents unexpectedly hauled off to jail after routine check-ins with immigration officials. One was an Afghan who'd helped

[See Habeas, A7]



HOUSEKEEPER Sabine Phillips reports abandoned furniture and debris along East Hollywood sidewalks.

Voices STEVE LOPEZ COLUMNIST

Stepping up, she cleans her own trashed streets

The first stop on Sabine Phillips' three-hour inspection of her neighborhood was at Fountain Avenue and St. Andrew's Place, where detached pieces of a sofa had been plopped onto the sidewalk as if this were an outdoor living room.

Phillips slid off her yellow Huffy cruiser, grabbed a pen, and entered the finding into her spiral notebook.

"This stretch is a common dumping ground," she told me, eyes hidden behind sunglasses under a floppy sun hat.

Her part-time assistant,

Keith Johnson, was wearing a "Trash Club Hollywood" T-shirt. He squeezed the handle of his garbage-grabbing tool to snare cookie and chip wrappers that floated near some empty Pacifico beer bottles and a Big Gulp container the size of a drum. When they report neighborhood problems to the city, Johnson said, "sometimes they're helpful and many times they're not, so we end up doing things on our own."

Much of the discarded furniture and other goods left on the streets end up being used to build home-

[See Lopez, A8]